

These numbers should make you worry. Give money to your children and you may ruin their lives. But is it better to ruin the lives of someone else's children?

One way or another, if you leave any surplus wealth behind, it's going to end up in someone's pocket. That person can benefit from it. Or not.

Merryn Somerset Webb, editor-in-chief of our own *MoneyWeek* magazine in the United Kingdom, says, "The great majority of entrepreneurs we write about have some money somewhere behind them."⁵

Many entrepreneurs—including the elder of your authors—are proud of the fact that they "started with nothing." But it is more a vanity than a fact. Nobody really starts with nothing. We set out from where we are. Perhaps we live at home, feeding at our parents' table while we prepare our business. Perhaps we depend on the kindness of strangers or a winning smile to help us get started. We all have something at the beginning and something at the end. The trick is to make the most of the middle.

But how?

One of Old Money's most precious secrets is time.

Here's another one: modesty.

It pays to be wary of knowledge, facts, and certainty. In business. Law. Investments. Character. Family relations. Everything connected with family money. Nobody really knows anything. It is all guesswork. The best we can hope to do is to guess well so that the space between the beginning and the end is filled well.

Be aware that you may not be able to do all you hope to do, and if you're not careful, you'll do considerable harm. Tread boldly, but carefully.

Also, be aware that almost everything you read or hear on the subject is either stupid, wrong, and/or self-serving. Very often, the professionals who offer to help keep family and money are "talking their book," encouraging you to do things that just, by coincidence, also put money in their pockets.

That is true, generally, in the investment world, too. The people who offer to make you money often have stakes in the investments they present. They sell and take commissions. They manage and take fees. They broker deals and take part of the upside.

While much of this conflict of interest is obvious, much of it isn't. Nearly all of Wall Street (that is to say, all of the financial industry) has a bias to